‘There are many tigers,’ he also noted, ‘and many partridges and turtle doves and much other fowl.’ For Akbar, this ancient site of pilgrimage and devotion was deeply moving, and he began the construction of a great fort here. ‘For a long time, His Majesty’s desire was to found a great city in the town of Piyag,’ agreed Abu’l Fazl, ‘where the rivers Ganges and Jamna join, which is regarded by the people of India with great reverence and which is a place of pilgrimage for the ascetics of the country and to build a choice fort there.’

From Prayag the fleet sailed down the Ganga, broad as an ocean. ‘Here is [a] great store of fish of sundry sorts,’ wrote Ralph Fitch, making the very same journey a few years later, ‘and of wild fowl, as of swans, geese, cranes and many other things. The country is very fruitful and populous.’ But by the time the Mughal fleet arrived at Benares, after sailing for twenty-six days, the waves were crashing against the boats as the coir ropes groaned against the wind. Many chose to disembark at this point, undone by the violence of the storms. After staying three days in Benares, the Mughal fleet sailed on and anchored near Sayyidpur, where the land army joined them. The harem and the princes were dispatched to Jaunpur and now as the fleet sailed down the Ganga towards Patna, the army kept pace on land and in the evening camped opposite the anchorage of the royal boats.

Akbar disembarked one day to ride one of his royal elephants, Mubarak Qadam, and through sheets of rain he plunged the elephant into the foaming water of the Ganga, now miles wide because of the torrential rain, followed by 500 elephants and their riders. All the camp followers were astounded at this powerful demonstration of the Padshah’s authority over the elements themselves. The message sent out to those who would dream of rebellion was equally clear. Every evening Akbar stopped to hunt with his cheetahs, keeping the machinery of war and empire running efficiently and smoothly at the same time. At Hajipur, the Mughal troops were joined by Munim Khan and it was decided to first capture this town because it supplied Patna and the rebellious Afghans. Akbar dispatched ‘into the midst of the raging stream 3000 fully equipped horsemen in boats with such ornamentation and display, that at the sight of it the eye was rejoiced…[and the boats were] filled with all store and munitions necessary for taking the fortress of Hajipur’. The fort was taken despite strong resistance and the heads of the Afghan leaders killed in the battle were brought by boat to Akbar who